

Slido Engagement Summary:
Superintendent's Student Voice Advisory Council
April 9, 2026

Of the 20 students surveyed during the April SVAC meeting, half the participants reported experiencing a big school change like attending a new school or experiencing a boundary change in the past. Students who experienced a major school change reported that they felt the most successful when they were anchored by consistent relationships with family, familiar peers, and had the active support of teachers. Students also valued a sense of communal solidarity; as students felt reassured knowing their peers were facing similar transitions and challenges. Ultimately, the combination of maintaining old connections and embracing new social circles created an emotional safety net for students navigating change.

Students reported that great schools are places where students feel included, safe, and supported in a diverse, resourced community. Feeling a sense of belonging (40%) and having strong relationships with teachers (30%) were the most important factors for feeling successful at school. Having lots of classes/programs (15%) being with friends (10%), being close to home (5%), and feeling safe (0%) mattered less.

When asked to rank what adults should protect when considering boundary changes, most students prioritized staying with friends, trusted teachers, and creating a safe and welcoming environment. However, when asked to choose between staying with friends and having access to more programs and opportunities, more students opted for programs and opportunities (62% vs. 38%). The vast majority of students would choose a school with more resources/classes than one closer to home (95% vs. 5%).

When asked "What makes a school feel like your school?" students reported that they felt ownership of their school community when they felt a deep sense of long-term belonging, sometimes built through years of attendance, shared family history, or teachers who truly know and believe in them. This feeling is reinforced by a welcoming daily atmosphere, where inclusive greetings, personalized lessons, and a lack of judgment from adults create a safe and "chill" environment. Ultimately, the school becomes "theirs" through meaningful engagement, including access to sports teams and music, and building personal relationships with school staff over time.

In response to the question, "What is something adults should never forget when making decisions like this?" students emphasized that decision-makers must never forget the impact their choices have on the daily lives of children, urging adults to prioritize student voices and the preservation of close-knit communities. They highlight the necessity of protecting essential programs, such as specialized classes (like dual language immersion and international baccalaureate programming) and diverse electives, which keep students engaged. Similarly, school changes would feel unfair for students if they lead to the fragmentation of communities, specifically through the loss of trusted teachers, friends, and staff who represent diverse backgrounds and trusted support systems.